

Litlanesfoss

A stunning Icelandic waterfall cascading over a remarkable outcrop of volcanic columns



Situated on the Hengifossá River in eastern Iceland, Litlanesfoss is a spectacular waterfall framed by a series of tall and exceptionally regular hexagonal basalt columns. Its total height of over 100 ft (30 m) includes two separate falls. The upper, smaller tier sits at an angle to the lower, near-vertical section, which falls into a small, bright-blue plunge pool. Litlanesfoss is one of several waterfalls dotted across the volcanic landscape of this part of Iceland, including Hengifoss, one of Iceland's tallest falls, just ½ mile (1 km) upstream.

Ancient lava flow

The Litlanesfoss Falls effectively cascade down the cross section of a thick ancient lava flow. The wide columns in the basalt rock are the result of the lava cooling relatively slowly over time. As it cooled and contracted, it formed joints, or fractures, that grew perpendicular to the base and surface of the lava flow. An array of straight and regular columnar jointing, as seen at Litlanesfoss, is known as a colonnade and is thought to have formed due to cooling from the base of the flow upward. Other well-known examples of columnar jointing include the Giant's Causeway in Ireland (see pp.164–65) and Fingal's Cave on the Scottish island of Staffa (see p.166).

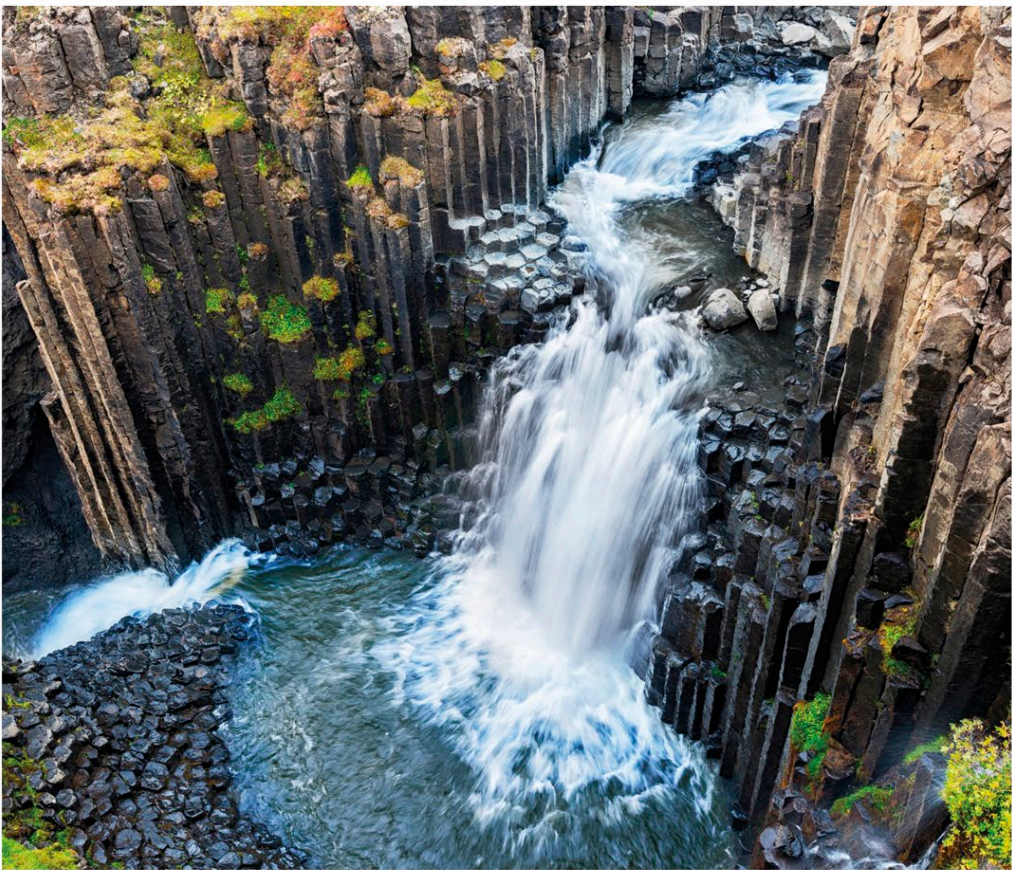


△ HORSETAIL FALLS

The lower, taller section of the waterfall cascades down in what is known as a horsetail formation, with the water fanning out as it falls.

▽ UPPER TIER

The upper tier of Litlanesfoss is much shorter and less steep. Water pools at the bottom before it plunges down the lower section.



RADIAL DRAINAGE

The broadly circular Lake District comprises a core of central mountains from which a series of valleys, lakes, and waterways radiates outward. This pattern has been produced by the uplifting of the underlying dome of rock millions of years ago.

